

Income in Her Hands, Nourishment at Home: Integrated Livelihoods and Maternal and Child Nutrition for 800 Munda Women in Arki Block, Khunti, Jharkhand

*A 24-month proposal by EcoKheti Foundation to the Grameen Vikas Foundation | All
16 Gram Panchayats of Arki Block | Budget: INR 60,00,000*

Location: Arki Block (all 16 Gram Panchayats), Khunti District, Jharkhand

Duration: 24 months

Budget: INR 60,00,000

Submitted to: Grameen Vikas Foundation

Submitted by: Prakash Kumar, Independent Development-Sector Consultant

Contents

- 1. Problem Statement
- 2. Project Objective
- 3. Operational Strategy
- 4. Activities
- 5. Implementation Timeline
- 6. Results Framework
- 7. Sustainability
- 8. Budget

Problem Statement

Purpose of this chapter

This chapter explains why 800 Scheduled Tribe women in Arki block, and the children who depend on them, remain trapped in poverty and poor health. It also explains why that condition will not resolve on its own. The argument is simple and rests entirely on the evidence available. In Arki, lack of income and lack of nourishment are not two separate problems that happen to share a geography. They are two halves of one cycle, each feeding the other, and any response that addresses only one will see its gains eroded by the other. The sections below examine the problem dimension by dimension and then show how the dimensions lock together. That locked structure is what the rest of this proposal is designed to break.

The geographic and administrative context

Arki is the most underserved block in Khunti district, which is itself among the tribal heartland districts of Jharkhand. "Most underserved" is an administrative judgement, but for the people who live there it has plain consequences. Public services arrive later, thinner and less reliably than elsewhere in the district. Frontline workers carry larger gaps, and fewer institutions exist to connect households to markets, credit and entitlements. When the block is the weakest link within an already disadvantaged district, households start from a lower base than their neighbours and have fewer external supports to lean on when a crop fails or a family member falls ill.

This proposal covers all 16 Gram Panchayats of the block. Blanket coverage is deliberate. In a block where deprivation is widespread rather than concentrated in a few pockets, selecting only some Panchayats would leave out households in equal need. It would also weaken the block-level relationships with government departments on which the convergence strategy depends.

The social and community structure

Roughly 80 percent of Arki's population belongs to Scheduled Tribes, predominantly the Munda community. This is the defining social fact of the block, and it cuts in two directions. The first is disadvantage. Across Jharkhand, 60 percent of Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe households live below the poverty line, well above the state average of about 46 percent. In a block that is four-fifths tribal, that gap is the ordinary condition of most families, not a marginal statistic.

The second direction matters just as much for programme design. Munda society has strong traditions of collective life and community decision-making. Any intervention that treats households as isolated units misses this resource. An approach that builds on collective structures, such as women's groups meeting regularly within their own hamlets, works with

the grain of the community rather than against it. This is why the strategy that follows is anchored in Self-Help Groups rather than in individual service delivery.

The economic and livelihoods dimension

Livelihoods in Arki depend on rain-fed agriculture and seasonal collection of forest produce. The target households are landless or near-landless, and the block offers little or no stable off-farm income. Each of these facts compounds the others.

Rain-fed agriculture on little or no land yields a small, uncertain harvest concentrated in one season. Forest produce adds income, but it is also seasonal and is usually sold raw, at the moment of collection, when prices are lowest and the household's need for cash is highest. Without off-farm work to fill the gaps, household income arrives in short bursts separated by long lean periods. The problem is therefore not only that incomes are low. It is that they are unstable. An unstable income forces families to make short-term choices, such as selling produce immediately, borrowing at high cost or cutting food consumption, that deepen poverty over time.

For a landless household the land-based pathway out of poverty is effectively closed, so income growth must come from sources that do not require land. Small livestock, kitchen-scale cultivation, value addition to forest produce that households already collect, and micro-enterprise all fit this description. The absence of such diversified sources today is the gap this project will fill.

Poverty and the absence of a safety margin

The 60 percent poverty rate among SC and ST households in Jharkhand, set against the state average of about 46 percent, means that poverty in Arki is both deeper and more widespread than in the state at large. Downstream, this means households have no buffer. A drought year, a sick child or a death in the family pushes them straight into distress, because they hold no savings, no insurable assets and no reliable access to formal credit. Formal financial services are designed around collateral and steady cash flow, and landless women with seasonal incomes have neither. Their exclusion from those services is therefore a structural consequence of the livelihood pattern described above. Building a savings habit and a credit history through group mechanisms is the most realistic route into the formal financial system for these women.

The gender dimension

The women at the centre of this proposal carry a double burden. They do much of the agricultural and forest-collection work and are primarily responsible for feeding the household and caring for children. Yet the income that passes through the household is rarely under their control. The objective of this project therefore specifies incomes "under their own control" and not simply higher household income.

Who controls income decides how it is spent. When women have independent earnings and a recognised say in spending, more of the money tends to go to food, children's needs and health care. A woman with no income of her own has no bargaining position when choices about food, rest during pregnancy or a clinic visit are made. Women's economic agency is therefore the mechanism through which income gains become nutrition gains, not a side benefit of the programme. The organisation's founding value of women's agency is, in Arki, a practical requirement of the Theory of Change.

Education and human capital

Female literacy in Arki block stands at 41.02 percent (Census 2011). Put plainly, well over half the women in the block cannot read or write. This shapes the problem in several ways. It limits women's ability to handle bank transactions, understand scheme application forms, keep simple accounts for a small enterprise or read health cards and counselling material. It increases their dependence on intermediaries, who may charge for access to entitlements that are free by right. It also reduces their confidence in dealing with institutions, from the bank branch to the block office.

Two design consequences follow. First, all training and counselling must rely on oral, visual and demonstration-based methods, not written material. Second, the SHG itself becomes a site of practical financial literacy, where maintaining registers and passbooks builds numeracy and institutional confidence through repetition. Low literacy also has an intergenerational edge. Maternal education is closely linked to child feeding and care practices, so the literacy gap among today's mothers is part of why child undernutrition persists.

Health and nutrition among women

According to NFHS-5, 65 percent of women in Jharkhand are anaemic. Among tribal women, 47 percent are undernourished, compared with 29 percent of non-tribal women. That gap of eighteen percentage points is the health expression of the same disadvantage visible in the poverty figures.

In human terms, anaemia and undernutrition mean chronic fatigue, reduced capacity for physical work, greater vulnerability to illness and higher risk during pregnancy and childbirth. For women whose livelihoods depend on physically demanding farm and forest work, this translates directly into lost productivity and lost income. A woman who is too exhausted to work a full day, or who falls ill during the harvest or collection season, earns less. Lower earnings mean less food, less diverse food and delayed care, which deepens the anaemia. This is the core of the cycle identified in the substance: economic vulnerability and health and nutrition deficits reinforce each other.

The causes of anaemia and undernutrition are partly about how much food a household has, and partly about knowledge, practice and access: whether iron and folic acid supplements are taken, whether diets include diverse food groups, and whether antenatal care is used. Income alone does not guarantee improved nutrition, and knowledge alone cannot be acted upon without the means. Both are needed.

Child undernutrition and the intergenerational cost

According to NFHS-5, 40 percent of children in Jharkhand are stunted; the logframe records the state figure as 39.6 percent. Stunting is the cumulative mark of chronic undernutrition, beginning in the womb of an undernourished mother and continuing through inadequate infant and young child feeding. Its effects are largely irreversible after early childhood. A stunted child is more likely to learn less in school, earn less as an adult and, if a girl, to become an undernourished mother herself.

This is why the impact statement of this proposal speaks of intergenerational poverty and malnutrition. An undernourished mother gives birth to a child at higher risk of stunting. A stunted child grows into an adult with reduced earning capacity. That adult's household remains poor and food-insecure, and the next child is born into the same conditions. The high rate of female undernutrition among tribal women and the high rate of child stunting are the same problem viewed at two points in the life cycle.

Access to government schemes and entitlements

India's public system offers a substantial set of relevant entitlements. They include the National Rural Livelihoods Mission, implemented in Jharkhand through JSLPS; wage employment under MGNREGA; subsidised grain through the Public Distribution System; supplementary nutrition and child growth services through ICDS; maternal and child health services under the National Health Mission; and maternity benefit under PMMVY. In principle, these schemes address almost every dimension described above.

In practice, the value of an entitlement depends on whether a household knows about it, can complete the process to enrol, and can hold the system to account for delivery. Each dimension of the problem works against this. Low female literacy makes paperwork a barrier. The block's underserved status means thin frontline presence. Lack of collective voice means individual women have little leverage. The exact enrolment and uptake gaps across the 16 Panchayats are not yet documented; the baseline survey will establish them and sharpen this analysis. The structural reasons why uptake is likely to fall short of entitlement are nonetheless clear. Closing that gap is among the most cost-effective actions available, because it unlocks public resources that already exist rather than creating parallel ones.

Seasonal distress and its social cost

When a household depends on seasonal agriculture and forest produce and has no stable off-farm income, the lean months must be survived somehow. The usual coping strategies in such conditions are reduced meals, distress borrowing and, in many rural households, members leaving to seek work elsewhere. The extent of seasonal distress migration from Arki is not quantified in the available evidence, and field data from the baseline would clarify it. Whatever form the coping takes, it lands most heavily on women. They reduce their own food intake first, take on additional work when others leave, and bear the care burden alone. Stable, diversified, local income sources that generate cash across more months of the year are the direct counter to this pattern.

The agro-ecological and environmental dimension

Dependence on rainfall and forests ties household welfare directly to environmental conditions the household cannot control. A weak monsoon reduces both the harvest and the forest yield, so the two main income sources can fail together rather than offsetting each other. A household with only these two sources has almost no diversification against climate risk.

Diversification into livestock, which can be sold when needed and acts as a store of value, and into kitchen gardens, which can be managed at household scale with limited water, spreads risk across sources with different vulnerabilities. Adding value to forest produce allows households to earn more from the same quantity collected, rather than extracting more from the forest. The livelihood choices in this proposal are shaped by this ecological reality.

Why the problem persists, and why it will not resolve on its own

Taken together, these dimensions form a closed system. Landlessness and rain-fed livelihoods produce low and unstable income. Poverty removes any buffer and excludes women from formal finance. Low literacy and weak institutional reach keep entitlements out of grasp. Lack of income under women's control limits spending on food and care. Poor diets and weak health practices produce anaemia and undernutrition. Undernourished women work less and earn less, and give birth to children at high risk of stunting. Those children inherit the same constraints.

No single external shock is holding Arki back, so no single correction will release it. Income interventions alone may raise earnings without changing diets, particularly if women do not control the income. Nutrition education alone asks women to adopt practices they cannot afford. Scheme enrolment alone delivers benefits that households may not know how to use well. The cycle has to be interrupted at several points at once, through a structure that women own and that can carry both the economic and the health work. The next chapter sets out the change this project will pursue on that basis.

Project Objective

The change sought

The analysis above points to a single conclusion: in Arki, income and nutrition must be addressed together, through women, and in a way women control. The objective of this project follows directly.

Over 24 months, the project will strengthen the economic independence of 800 Scheduled Tribe women in Arki block through stable, diversified incomes under their own control, while improving the maternal and child nutrition of their households.

For whom

The project serves 800 Scheduled Tribe women of reproductive age, predominantly from the Munda community, drawn from landless and near-landless households across all 16 Gram Panchayats of Arki block, Khunti district, Jharkhand. Their households, and in particular their young children, are the secondary beneficiaries. The project will reach 400 family members directly with maternal and child nutrition and health knowledge, and 500 households will establish kitchen gardens.

Women of reproductive age are the right focus because they stand at the point where the cycle can be broken. They are the earners whose productivity is sapped by anaemia, the decision-makers over household food, and the mothers whose nutrition shapes the next generation's health.

What success looks like

The objective translates into two linked outcomes. First, the 800 women will have increased and diversified household incomes under their own control, targeting an average income increase of at least 50 percent and at least two income sources per woman. Second, the women and their families will adopt improved maternal and child health, nutrition and care practices, targeting at least 60 percent of women achieving minimum dietary diversity.

Together these outcomes contribute to the longer-term impact of reduced intergenerational poverty and malnutrition among Scheduled Tribe households in Arki, tracked through under-5 stunting in beneficiary households against a Jharkhand baseline of 39.6 percent (NFHS-5). The target is for this figure to trend below the block baseline. The next chapter explains how the project will get there.

Operational Strategy

Purpose of this chapter

The problem analysis showed a cycle with many points of reinforcement, and the objective committed the project to interrupting it on both the economic and the nutritional side at once. This chapter explains the approach that makes that possible. It covers the choice of delivery platform, the logic that ties the two strands together, the sequencing across 24 months, and the reliance on public systems rather than parallel structures. Each choice is justified by the conditions in Arki described earlier.

One platform, two strands: the SHG as the delivery structure

The central strategic decision is to use a single community platform, the women's Self-Help Group, to deliver both the livelihood and the health and nutrition strands. The 800 women will be organised into approximately 53 SHGs, averaging about fifteen members each, with regular savings and internal credit.

This choice is grounded in the context. First, it builds on Munda traditions of collective life, which gives the groups a social foundation that externally imposed structures lack. Second, it responds to the gender analysis. A group of women meeting regularly, pooling savings and making collective decisions builds precisely the agency and bargaining position that individual women lack, and it establishes a recognised space where women's earnings are discussed as their own. Third, it answers the problem of financial exclusion. Group savings and credit create a track record that opens the door to bank linkage, which landless women with seasonal incomes could not obtain individually. Fourth, it addresses low literacy. Keeping registers and passbooks in a supportive group setting builds practical numeracy and institutional confidence.

A single platform is also efficient and coherent. Running separate livelihood groups and health groups would double the demand on women's time, split their attention and fragment the relationship with the project. When the same group that manages savings and plans a goat enterprise also discusses dietary diversity and antenatal care, the link between earning and nourishing becomes part of the group's own conversation.

The integration logic: assets and meetings that serve both ends

Integration in this project is built into the design, not asserted. It works through two mechanisms.

The first is **dual-purpose assets**. Kitchen gardens and livestock generate both income and household nutrition. A kitchen garden supplies vegetables for the family's plate, directly improving dietary diversity, and its surplus can be sold. Small livestock such as goats and poultry build a saleable asset that acts as a buffer in lean months, and they can also contribute to household diets. The livelihood choices were selected because they serve both outcomes at once and because they require little or no land, which suits landless households.

The second is **dual-purpose meetings**. SHG meetings host both livelihood and health learning. Nutrition counselling on iron and folic acid supplementation, infant and young child feeding, antenatal care and dietary diversity is delivered within the regular meeting cycle and reinforced through household visits. This means health messages reach women repeatedly, in a trusted setting, alongside the financial discussions that give them the means to act on those messages.

Through these two mechanisms the strategy targets the reinforcing cycle directly. Higher, women-controlled income makes improved nutrition affordable. Improved nutrition and health raise women's capacity to work and earn. The cycle that currently runs downward is engineered to run upward.

Sequencing: three phases over 24 months

The project unfolds in three overlapping phases, each building the conditions for the next.

Phase 1: Mobilisation and group formation (Quarters 1 to 3). Community mobilisation across all 16 Gram Panchayats, formation and strengthening of SHGs, and the baseline survey in Quarter 1. Nothing else can work until groups exist, meet regularly and have begun saving, so this phase comes first. Nutrition counselling and convergence facilitation begin in Quarter 2, as soon as groups are meeting, so that the health strand starts early rather than being added later.

Phase 2: Capacity-building and asset support (Quarters 2 to 6). Livelihood skills training, distribution of productive assets and input kits, and establishment of kitchen gardens in Quarters 3 to 5, timed so that women receive assets after they have the skills to manage them. Bank linkage, scheme enrolment and market linkage begin in Quarter 3, once groups have a savings record to show. A midline review in Quarter 4 allows course correction.

Phase 3: Consolidation, market linkage and transition (Quarters 7 and 8). Market and financial linkages are deepened, nutrition counselling and convergence continue, and the project's role steps back as the SHGs and public-system relationships take over. The endline survey in Quarter 8 measures change against the baseline.

This sequence reflects a principle drawn from field experience. Assets given before groups are strong and skills are in place are often lost or sold off. Assets given to organised, trained women with market and credit connections become the foundation of a lasting livelihood.

Convergence with public systems

The project does not build parallel services. It connects women to entitlements that already exist and are theirs by right: NRLM through JSLPS, MGNREGA, PDS, ICDS and the National Health Mission, along with maternity benefit under PMMVY. At community level, convergence runs through the ASHA, the Anganwadi Worker and the Village Health, Sanitation and Nutrition Day.

This is a strategic choice for three reasons. It is cost-effective, because every rupee of public entitlement unlocked adds to project resources without adding to project cost. It is sustainable, because the relationships between SHGs and public frontline workers persist after the project ends. It is empowering, because women who learn to claim their entitlements collectively gain a capacity they keep. Aligning SHGs with the NRLM structure in Jharkhand also positions them to continue within the state's own livelihood architecture. This reflects EcoKheti Foundation's value of convergence with public systems and its experience of community-based livelihoods and nutrition programming in tribal Jharkhand.

Why this approach fits Arki

The strategy answers each dimension of the problem. Landlessness is met with land-light livelihoods. Income instability is met with diversification across livestock, gardens, forest-produce value addition and micro-enterprise. Financial exclusion is met with group savings and bank linkage. Low literacy is met with oral, practical and group-based learning. Lack of women's control over income is met with a women-owned platform. Nutrition deficits are met with counselling that sits alongside the means to act on it. Weak access to entitlements is met with facilitated convergence. The next chapter traces how these elements produce results, level by level.

Activities

Purpose of this chapter

The results chain set out what the project will achieve. This chapter explains what the project will do and, more importantly, how each cluster of activities produces its result. The activities are organised in the sequence they unfold across the 24 months. For each cluster, the chapter identifies the output it builds and the mechanism by which it builds it, so that the activities read as the working parts of the Theory of Change.

Cluster 1: Community mobilisation and SHG formation and strengthening (Quarters 1 to 3)

Builds Output 1; is the foundation for all outputs.

The project begins with mobilisation across all 16 Gram Panchayats of Arki block. Five Community Mobilisers, each covering roughly three Panchayats, will work hamlet by hamlet to identify landless and near-landless Scheduled Tribe women of reproductive age, explain the project, and support women to form or strengthen groups of their own choosing. Where women already belong to groups, the project will strengthen those groups rather than create duplicates, consistent with the principle of working within existing structures.

Groups will be supported to establish regular meetings, agree their own rules, begin regular savings and start internal lending. Mobilisers will train group members in record-keeping using simple, visual methods suited to a context where female literacy is 41.02 percent, so that maintaining registers becomes a vehicle for practical numeracy.

How this produces its result. Groups that meet regularly and save consistently for several months develop the trust, discipline and track record that make them functional institutions. This is measured through SHG registers and bank passbooks. That functionality is the precondition for everything that follows. It is why group formation starts in Quarter 1 and asset distribution does not begin until Quarter 3. The Community Mobilisers are the largest personnel investment in the budget, at INR 18,00,000 over 120 person-months, which reflects the weight the design places on this foundation.

Cluster 2: Livelihood skills training (Quarters 2 to 6)

Builds Output 2; feeds Outcome 1.

Once groups are in place, the project will deliver livelihood skills training in 20 batches of 40 women, reaching all 800 women, at a cost of INR 30,000 per batch based on NRLM training cost norms. Training will cover five livelihood areas: agriculture, including kitchen-scale cultivation; poultry; goatery; value addition to non-timber forest produce; and micro-enterprise.

Each woman, in discussion with her group, will choose livelihood options suited to her household's labour, space and existing activities. Diversification is a stated aim, so women will be encouraged to build at least two income streams. Training will be practical and demonstration-based, with follow-up support in the field.

How this produces its result. The five areas were chosen because they fit landless households. None requires significant land, and each draws on resources households already have: labour, homestead space and access to the forest. Forest-produce value addition directly addresses the problem of raw produce sold at the lowest prices, allowing households to earn more from what they already collect. Skills come before assets so that women can manage livestock and gardens well from the start, which reduces the risk of assets being lost or sold in distress.

Cluster 3: Provision of productive assets and input kits (Quarters 3 to 6)

Builds Output 2; feeds Outcomes 1 and 2.

Trained women will receive productive assets and input kits matched to their chosen livelihoods. These include 100 goat units of two does each, at INR 12,000 per unit in line with state livestock scheme norms, and input kits for other enterprises.

Goats are central to the asset strategy because they suit landless households, reproduce to build herd value over time, and act as a store of wealth that can be sold when cash is needed, providing the buffer that households currently lack.

How this produces its result. Assets convert skills into production. Timing the distribution from Quarter 3, after groups are functioning and training is under way, means assets reach women who are organised and prepared. The group structure adds accountability and peer support in caring for livestock. Because livestock can be sold in lean months, this cluster directly counters the income instability identified in the problem analysis.

Cluster 4: SHG-bank linkage, scheme enrolment and market linkage (Quarters 3 to 8)

Builds Output 3; feeds Outcome 1.

From Quarter 3, once groups have built a savings record, the project will support them to open bank accounts and access credit through SHG-bank linkage. At the same time, it will help women enrol in relevant government schemes, specifically NRLM through JSLPS, MGNREGA and PMMVY. It will also link producers to markets for livestock, garden surplus, value-added forest produce and micro-enterprise goods.

This cluster runs through to the end of the project, deepening in Phase 3 as the focus shifts to consolidation and transition.

How this produces its result. Each linkage does distinct work. Bank linkage gives groups access to larger and cheaper credit than internal savings allow, so enterprises can grow and distress borrowing is reduced. Scheme enrolment unlocks public resources, such as wage employment under MGNREGA during lean periods and maternity benefit under PMMVY

during pregnancy, that add to household income at no cost to the project. Market linkage ensures that increased production becomes increased income. This cluster turns the gains from Clusters 2 and 3 into the durable, diversified income that Outcome 1 measures.

Cluster 5: Nutrition counselling through SHG meetings and household visits (Quarters 2 to 8)

Builds Output 4; feeds Outcome 2.

Nutrition counselling begins in Quarter 2, as soon as groups are meeting, and continues until the end of the project. It covers four areas: iron and folic acid supplementation, directly targeting the high burden of anaemia; infant and young child feeding; antenatal care; and dietary diversity.

Counselling will take place during regular SHG meetings, so that health learning sits alongside livelihood discussion. It will be reinforced through household visits, which also reach 400 family members who influence decisions about food, rest and care-seeking.

How this produces its result. Embedding counselling in SHG meetings means women receive health messages repeatedly, from a trusted source, in the same setting where they discuss income. They hear how to act on the knowledge in the same place they gain the means to do so. Household visits carry the messages to family members whose support a woman needs to change practices. Starting early and continuing for seven quarters provides the sustained exposure that behaviour change requires. The resulting shift in practice is measured by the dietary diversity indicator.

Cluster 6: Kitchen garden establishment (Quarters 3 to 5)

Builds Output 5; feeds Outcomes 2 and 1.

The project will support 500 households to establish kitchen gardens, providing seeds, saplings and technical support. Input kits are budgeted at INR 1,500 per household, a rate to be confirmed locally. Technical support will help households maintain gardens across seasons, and harvest logs will track production.

How this produces its result. The kitchen garden is where the integration logic becomes visible. Vegetables grown at home go directly onto the family's plate, improving the dietary diversity that nutrition counselling promotes, without depending on cash income. This matters most in the lean months when purchased food is hardest to afford. Surplus can be sold, adding a small income stream. Because the output is measured as functional gardens at endline, the technical support is designed to help gardens last beyond the first harvest.

Cluster 7: Convergence facilitation with ASHA, AWW and VHSND (Quarters 2 to 8)

Supports Outputs 3 and 4; feeds both outcomes and sustainability.

From Quarter 2 onward, the project will actively connect SHGs with the frontline public health and nutrition system: the ASHA, the Anganwadi Worker and the Village Health, Sanitation and

Nutrition Day. This includes encouraging women to attend VHSNDs, linking pregnant and lactating women and young children to ICDS and National Health Mission services, and building working relationships between groups and frontline workers. It also connects women to PDS entitlements.

How this produces its result. Counselling creates demand for services such as antenatal care and iron and folic acid supplements. Convergence ensures that demand is met by the public system. The ASHA and AWW gain an organised, informed group of women to work with, which makes their own outreach more effective. The women gain reliable access to services that are theirs by right. These relationships are built to outlast the project, which makes this cluster a central pillar of sustainability.

Cluster 8: Monitoring and documentation (Quarters 1, 4 and 8)

Underpins all results.

A baseline survey in Quarter 1 will establish the income, dietary diversity and scheme-uptake figures that are currently marked "to be established" in the logframe. A midline review in Quarter 4 will assess progress and allow course correction. An endline survey in Quarter 8, including anthropometric measurement and a knowledge, attitudes and practices survey, will measure change at outcome and impact level. Routine monitoring through SHG registers, bank passbooks, harvest logs and ICDS records will run throughout.

How this produces its result. Monitoring turns the Theory of Change from an assumption into something that is tested. The baseline also serves the programme directly, by showing where scheme-uptake gaps are greatest and where livelihood support is most needed.

Management

A Project Coordinator, budgeted at INR 8,40,000 over 24 months in line with NRLM project-staff norms, will manage all outputs, supervise the Community Mobilisers, lead coordination with block-level government departments, and oversee monitoring. The combination of a single coordinator and five field-based mobilisers keeps the structure lean and places the weight of staffing in the community.

Implementation Timeline

Activity	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Q5	Q6	Q7	Q8
Community mobilisation & SHG formation								
Livelihood skills training								
Provision of productive assets & input kits								
SHG-bank linkage, scheme enrolment & market linkage								
Nutrition counselling (SHG meetings & household visits)								
Kitchen garden establishment								
Convergence facilitation (ASHA, AWW, VHSND)								
Monitoring & documentation (baseline, midline, endline)								

Shaded cells indicate active quarters. Q1–Q2: mobilisation and group formation. Q3–Q6: capacity-building and asset support. Q7–Q8: consolidation, market linkage and transition.

Results Framework

Purpose of this chapter

The strategy explained how the project will work. This chapter sets out what it will achieve, tracing the results chain from the outputs the project directly delivers, through the outcomes these make possible, to the impact to which they contribute. At each level the chapter explains why that level follows from the one below. The logic is set out from the top down, starting with the ultimate change sought, and is then justified from the bottom up.

Impact: reduced intergenerational poverty and malnutrition

The long-term change to which this project contributes is **reduced intergenerational poverty and malnutrition among Scheduled Tribe households in Arki block**. This impact mirrors the problem analysis, which showed that poverty and malnutrition in Arki pass from mothers to children through a reinforcing cycle.

The impact indicator is under-5 stunting prevalence in beneficiary households, measured against a baseline of 39.6 percent (NFHS-5 Jharkhand), with the target of trending below the block baseline. It will be verified through an endline anthropometric survey and ICDS records. Stunting is chosen because it is the most direct measure of the intergenerational transmission the project seeks to interrupt. It is also honest about attribution. Stunting reflects cumulative nutrition over time and is influenced by many factors, so a 24-month project contributes to a downward trend rather than claiming to eliminate it. The project's direct accountability lies at outcome level.

Outcome 1: increased and diversified incomes under women's control

800 Scheduled Tribe women have increased and diversified household incomes under their own control.

The indicators are average annual income and the number of income sources. Targets are an increase of at least 50 percent in income and at least two income sources per woman, against a baseline to be established by the project's baseline survey. Verification will be through baseline and endline income surveys and SHG records.

The two indicators respond to the two economic problems identified earlier: low income and unstable income. A higher average addresses the first. Two or more sources address the second, because a household earning from livestock and a kitchen garden in addition to seasonal farm and forest work has income arriving across more of the year and from sources with different risks. The emphasis on women's control connects this outcome to the next. It is controlled income that is most likely to reach food and care.

Outcome 2: improved maternal and child health, nutrition and care practices

800 Scheduled Tribe women and their families adopt improved maternal and child health, nutrition and care practices.

The indicator is the percentage of women achieving minimum dietary diversity, with a target of at least 60 percent, against a baseline to be established. Verification will be through an endline knowledge, attitudes and practices survey and ICDS records.

Dietary diversity is chosen because it captures the point where knowledge, means and practice meet. A woman achieves a diverse diet only if she knows why it matters, has access to diverse foods, from her garden, her livestock or her income, and has the say to act on it. The indicator therefore tests the integration logic directly. Improved dietary diversity among women of reproductive age is also the most immediate pathway to reducing maternal anaemia and undernutrition and, over time, child stunting.

How the outcomes connect to the impact

The two outcomes are designed to reinforce each other, reversing the cycle described in the problem analysis. Outcome 1 gives households the means, and women the control, to feed their families better. Outcome 2 ensures that those means are turned into better diets and care practices. Better-nourished women are more productive earners, which strengthens Outcome 1 in turn. Children born to and raised by better-nourished mothers, in households with more stable incomes, are at lower risk of stunting. This is the pathway from outcomes to impact.

Outputs: what the project delivers directly

Five outputs, all within the project's direct control, together make the outcomes possible.

Output 1: 800 women organised into approximately 53 functioning SHGs with savings and credit. Measured by the number of functional SHGs, from a baseline of zero to a target of about 53, verified through SHG registers and bank passbooks. This output is the foundation for all others. It creates the platform through which every other output is delivered and gives women the collective strength on which their economic agency rests.

Output 2: 800 women equipped with diversified livelihood skills and productive assets. Skills training in agriculture, poultry, goatery, forest-produce value addition and micro-enterprise, combined with productive assets and input kits, gives women the capacity and the means to build new income sources. This output feeds Outcome 1 most directly.

Output 3: 800 women linked to markets, government schemes and financial services. Skills and assets create production; markets turn production into income, credit allows enterprises to grow, and schemes add public resources to household budgets. Without this output, gains from Output 2 would stay small and fragile.

Output 4: 800 women and 400 family members reached with maternal and child nutrition and health knowledge. Counselling through SHG meetings and household visits builds the knowledge that Outcome 2 requires. Reaching family members matters because decisions

about food, rest in pregnancy and care-seeking are often made jointly. Changing the woman's knowledge without shifting the household's views would limit what she can do.

Output 5: 500 household kitchen gardens established and maintained. Measured by functional gardens at endline, from a baseline of zero to a target of 500, verified through field verification and harvest logs. This is the clearest example of the integration logic, contributing to dietary diversity under Outcome 2 while generating saleable surplus under Outcome 1. The indicator deliberately measures gardens that are still functional at endline, not gardens established, because only a maintained garden changes diets.

Why the chain holds

Each level depends on the one below. Without functioning groups there is no platform for training, linkage or counselling. Without skills, assets and linkages, income cannot rise or diversify. Without knowledge and home-grown food, income will not reliably translate into better diets. Without both improved income and improved practice, the intergenerational cycle continues. The project measures progress at every level through baseline, midline and endline surveys and through routine SHG and ICDS records, so that each link in the chain is tested rather than assumed. The next chapter describes the activities that produce each output.

Level	Result statement	Indicator	Baseline	Target	Means of verification
Impact	Reduced poverty and malnutrition among ST households in Arki	Under-5 stunting prevalence in beneficiary HHs	39.6% (NFHS-5 Jharkhand)	Trending below block baseline	Endline anthropometric survey; ICDS records
Outcome 1	800 women have increased, diversified incomes	Average annual income; number of income sources	To be established by baseline survey	≥50% income increase; ≥2 sources	Baseline/endline income survey; SHG records
Outcome 2	Improved maternal & child nutrition practices	% women with minimum dietary diversity	To be established	≥60% of women	Endline KAP survey; ICDS records
Output 1	Functioning SHGs with savings & credit	Number of functional SHGs	0	~53 SHGs	SHG registers; bank passbooks
Output 5	Household kitchen gardens	Functional gardens at endline	0	500 gardens	Field verification; harvest logs

Sustainability

Purpose of this chapter

The activities described above will run for 24 months. The problem they address has persisted across generations. This chapter explains why the gains will outlast the project period. The answer lies in design choices made from the start: every structure the project builds is owned by the community or embedded in public systems, and every asset it provides is designed to keep generating value.

Community ownership through the SHGs

The approximately 53 SHGs are the backbone of sustainability. They are women's own institutions, formed around their own rules, savings and decisions, not project structures that dissolve when funding ends. By the close of the project, groups will have up to two years of savings and internal lending history, bank accounts and, for many, access to bank credit. A group with its own savings pool, a credit relationship with a bank and members who understand how to manage both has every reason to continue meeting. This reflects EcoKheti Foundation's commitment to community ownership. The project invests heavily in group formation at the outset precisely so that the groups are strong enough to stand alone.

The SHGs also carry forward the health and nutrition work. Because nutrition learning has been part of the regular meeting cycle from Quarter 2, discussions of diet, antenatal care and child feeding become part of group practice rather than an external add-on that stops when project staff leave.

Integration into the state's livelihood architecture

Convergence with NRLM, implemented in Jharkhand through JSLPS, positions the SHGs within the state's own long-term livelihood structure. Groups aligned with NRLM can continue to access its support, including further capacity-building and financial linkages, after the project ends. The project therefore functions as an on-ramp into a public system with a permanent mandate, not as a stand-alone intervention.

Self-sustaining productive assets

The livelihood assets are chosen to renew themselves. Goats reproduce, so a unit of two does can grow into a larger herd over time and build household wealth well beyond the project period. Kitchen gardens, once established and understood, can be maintained through saved seed and household labour. Skills in poultry, goatery, forest-produce value addition and micro-enterprise stay with the women. Market linkages established during the project give women continuing outlets for their products. Because incomes are diversified across at least two sources, households are less likely to be forced into distress sale of assets when one source fails.

Durable relationships with public health and nutrition systems

Convergence with the ASHA, the Anganwadi Worker, the VHSND, ICDS, the National Health Mission and PDS builds relationships between organised women and public frontline services that do not depend on the project. Women who have learned to attend VHSNDs, claim supplementary nutrition and maternity benefits and use antenatal services will continue to do so, and their groups give them the collective confidence to hold services to account. Scheme enrolment under MGNREGA and PMMVY, once secured, continues to deliver benefits.

Lasting change in knowledge, agency and practice

The deepest form of sustainability lies with the women themselves. A woman who controls her own income, understands why dietary diversity and iron supplementation matter, and has a recognised voice in her household and her group does not lose these capacities when a project closes. Reaching 400 family members helps ensure that improved practices are supported within households rather than resting on the woman alone. Because maternal nutrition and child feeding practices shape children's growth, gains made during these 24 months carry forward into the health of the next generation.

Planned transition

Phase 3, in Quarters 7 and 8, is dedicated to consolidation and transition. During this period the project's role deliberately steps back while groups take on more responsibility for their own savings, credit, market dealings and engagement with frontline workers. The endline survey in Quarter 8 will document what has been achieved and where continued support from public systems is most needed.

Conclusion

This proposal began from a cycle in which poverty and malnutrition reinforce each other in Arki block and pass from mothers to children. It responds with a single, women-owned platform that raises and diversifies incomes under women's control, turns those incomes into better nutrition through integrated learning and dual-purpose assets, and connects women permanently to the public systems meant to serve them. The project addresses the cycle at several points at once, and it leaves behind durable institutions, renewing assets and lasting capacity. That combination gives the 800 Munda women of Arki, and their children, a realistic chance to break the pattern of intergenerational poverty and malnutrition. EcoKheti Foundation requests the support of the Grameen Vikas Foundation to make this possible.

Budget

Item	Unit	Unit cost	Qty	Total	Contributes to	Source
A. Personnel & Salaries						
Project Coordinator	month	35,000	24	8,40,000	Management of all outputs	NRLM project-staff norms
Community Mobilisers (5)	month	15,000	120	18,00,000	Output 1 — SHG formation	Prevailing NGO field-staff rates, Jharkhand
Subtotal — Personnel & Salaries				26,40,000		
B. Capital Expenditure						
Project two-wheeler for field mobility (illustrative)	unit	[confirm]	2	[to confirm]	Field delivery across 16 GPs	Illustrative — confirm or remove
Subtotal — Capital Expenditure				—		
C. Programme / Activity Costs						
Livelihood skills training	batch of 40	30,000	20	6,00,000	Output 2 — skills	NRLM training cost norms
Goat units (2 does each)	unit	12,000	100	12,00,000	Output 2 assets → Outcome 1	State livestock scheme norms
Kitchen garden input kits	household	1,500	500	7,50,000	Output 5 → Outcome 2	[rate — confirm locally]
Subtotal — Programme / Activity Costs				25,50,000		
D. Administrative / Overheads						
Block office rent & utilities (illustrative)	month	[confirm]	24	[to confirm]	Programme operations	Illustrative — confirm or remove
Subtotal — Administrative / Overheads				—		
Grand Total				51,90,000		

Subtotals and grand total sum only the costed lines; lines marked to confirm are excluded until priced.

Income in Her Hands, Nourishment at Home: Integrated Livelihoods and Maternal and Child Nutrition for 800 Munda Women in Arki Block, Khunti, Jharkhand

EcoKheti Foundation

Ranchi, Jharkhand

contact@example.org

Prepared with the Proposal Development Agent · Method by Prakash Kumar